

Chapter 13 - Subject-Verb Concord

Subject-Verb Concord

Subject-verb concord is the grammatical rule that states that a verb must agree with its subject in number and person. This means that a singular subject requires a singular verb, while a plural subject requires a plural verb. This rule is essential because it helps sentences sound correct and makes their meaning clear to the reader. Many grammatical errors occur when writers fail to identify the true subject of a sentence. Such mistakes are common when extra words or phrases come between the subject and the verb. Subject-verb concord applies to all types of sentences, including statements, questions, and negative sentences. It is a fundamental rule taught from the early stages of learning English. Correct use of subject-verb concord improves accuracy in both writing and speaking. A strong understanding of this rule is important for scoring well in school examinations.

The boy runs fast every morning.

She enjoys reading storybooks.

The players are practicing on the ground.

They have completed their homework.

My cousin lives in a nearby town.

Subject

The subject of a sentence is the person, place, thing, or idea about which something is said. It usually performs the action of the verb or is described by the verb. In most English sentences, the subject appears before the verb, which helps in identifying it easily. The subject answers the questions “who?” or “what?” asked before the verb. A subject can be a noun, a pronoun, a noun phrase, or even a gerund. Sometimes the subject is a long phrase, which can confuse students while choosing the correct verb. In interrogative sentences, the subject may come after the verb. In imperative sentences, the subject “you” is usually understood but not written. Identifying the subject correctly is the first step in applying subject-verb concord rules.

The teacher explains the lesson clearly.

My younger sister loves drawing.

Everyone enjoyed the school picnic.

The large tree fell during the storm.



Swimming improves physical fitness.

Verb

A verb is a word that shows an action, a state of being, or a condition. It tells us what the subject does or what happens to the subject. Every complete sentence must contain a verb, otherwise it cannot express a full idea. Verbs can show physical actions like running or writing. They can also show mental actions like thinking or believing. Some verbs express a state, such as being happy or feeling tired. Verbs change their form to show tense, number, and person. Helping verbs are often used with main verbs to form different tenses. Choosing the correct verb depends on correctly identifying the subject of the sentence.

She writes neatly in her notebook.

They are playing in the park.

He felt tired after the match.

The baby slept peacefully.

We have finished our project.

Rule 1: Singular subject takes a singular verb

When the subject of a sentence is singular, the verb used with it must also be singular. This rule is one of the simplest rules of subject-verb concord. In the present tense, singular verbs often end with “s” or “es.” Students often get confused because plural nouns also end with “s.” The verb does not change just because other words come between the subject and the verb. The real subject must always be identified correctly. Proper nouns that refer to one person or thing are also singular. This rule applies to sentences in both spoken and written English. Careful reading helps avoid mistakes related to this rule.

The girl sings beautifully.

My father works in an office.

The dog barks loudly at night.

A student needs discipline.



The child cries for help.

Rule 2: Plural subject takes a plural verb

When the subject of a sentence is plural, the verb must also be plural. Plural verbs do not take “s” or “es” in the present tense. This rule helps distinguish between singular and plural verb forms. Plural subjects include nouns ending in “s” and pronouns like “we” and “they.” Students often make mistakes by adding “s” to plural verbs. Understanding the meaning of the subject is very important. This rule is commonly tested in grammar exercises. Regular practice helps students apply this rule correctly. Correct agreement improves sentence clarity.

The boys play cricket every evening.

Students work hard for success.

The teachers are attending a meeting.

My parents travel frequently.

Dogs guard the house at night.

Rule 3: Two subjects joined by “and” take a plural verb

When two subjects are joined by the conjunction “and,” they usually take a plural verb. This is because “and” combines two separate persons or things. Even if both subjects are singular, together they form a plural subject. This rule applies to nouns as well as pronouns. Students should remember that “and” generally increases number. This rule is used very frequently in daily speech. There are some exceptions, which are covered in other rules. Understanding this rule helps avoid common agreement errors. Reading the sentence carefully helps in applying it correctly.

Ravi and Mohan are best friends.

The teacher and the principal are present.

Bread and butter are served together.

My brother and I enjoy music.

Books and notebooks are kept on the table.



Rule 4: Two subjects joined by “and” referring to the same person or thing take a singular verb

When two subjects joined by “and” refer to the same person or thing, a singular verb is used. In such sentences, the two nouns describe one individual or object. Usually, the first noun has an article, while the second does not. Students often mistake these sentences as plural. Understanding the meaning of the sentence is very important here. This rule is common with titles, professions, and roles. It helps avoid incorrect verb usage. This rule is often tested in advanced grammar questions. Careful interpretation prevents errors.

The poet and singer is invited to the event.

The owner and manager is on leave today.

The writer and editor works late hours.

The teacher and guide helps students.

The founder and chairman leads the company.

Rule 5: Subjects joined by “or, nor, either...or, neither...nor” agree with the nearest subject

When subjects are joined by “or,” “nor,” “either...or,” or “neither...nor,” the verb agrees with the nearest subject. This is known as the rule of proximity. The verb is chosen according to the subject closest to it. Students often get confused when the subjects differ in number. Careful reading of the sentence helps in choosing the correct verb. This rule applies to both nouns and pronouns. It is commonly tested in fill-in-the-blank questions. Practice is necessary to master this rule. Correct usage improves grammatical accuracy.

Neither the teacher nor the students are ready.

Either the boys or the girl is responsible.

Neither the players nor the coach was present.

Either my father or my uncles are coming.

Neither the books nor the bag is missing.



Rule 6: Subjects followed by “with, along with, together with, as well as” agree with the main subject

When the subject is followed by phrases like “with,” “along with,” “together with,” or “as well as,” the verb agrees with the main subject. These phrases do not change the number of the subject. Students often wrongly treat the second noun as part of the subject. The words after these phrases only add extra information. Identifying the main subject is very important. This rule helps avoid common agreement mistakes. It is often tested in error correction exercises. Correct understanding leads to better sentence formation.

The teacher, along with the students, is arriving.

My brother, as well as his friends, is invited.

The captain, with the team, is practicing.

The principal, together with the staff, supports the plan.

The girl, along with her parents, is waiting.

Rule 7: Each, every, everyone, everybody, someone, nobody take a singular verb

Words like “each,” “every,” “everyone,” “everybody,” “someone,” and “nobody” are singular in meaning. Although they may refer to many people, they are treated as singular. Therefore, they always take a singular verb. Students often use plural verbs with these words by mistake. Understanding their meaning helps avoid confusion. This rule applies in all tenses. It is commonly tested in objective questions. Correct usage improves grammatical accuracy. Regular practice helps in remembering this rule.

Each student has a textbook.

Everyone enjoys the morning assembly.

Somebody is knocking at the door.

Nobody knows the answer.

Every child needs care.

Rule 8: Collective nouns usually take a singular verb

Collective nouns refer to a group of people or things taken as a single unit. When the group acts together, a singular verb is used. Words like “team,” “class,” and “family” are collective nouns. Students often feel confused while choosing the correct verb form. The meaning of the sentence helps decide the verb. When the group is considered as one whole, the verb is singular. This rule is important in formal writing. Correct usage improves clarity and correctness.

The class is attentive.

The team wins the match.

The family lives in a large house.

The committee meets today.

The jury gives its verdict.

Rule 9: Collective nouns showing division take a plural verb

When a collective noun refers to members acting separately, a plural verb is used. In such cases, the focus is on individuals rather than the group as a whole. This rule is often confused with the previous one. Understanding the context of the sentence is essential. Plural verbs show that members are acting independently. This rule is tested in advanced grammar questions. Practice helps students distinguish between unity and division. Correct usage improves sentence meaning.

The team are arguing among themselves.

The family are watching different shows.

The class are writing their answers.

The jury are divided in opinion.

The committee are discussing their views.

Rule 10: Uncountable nouns take a singular verb

Uncountable nouns refer to things that cannot be counted individually. Words like “water,” “milk,” “information,” and “furniture” are uncountable nouns.



These nouns always take a singular verb. Students often mistakenly treat them as plural. Uncountable nouns do not change their form in plural. This rule applies in all tenses. Correct usage is important in both spoken and written English. Understanding this rule prevents common grammatical errors.

Milk is good for health.

Information is easily available online.

Furniture is arranged neatly.

Advice is helpful.

Sugar is sweet.

Rule 11: Subjects like news, mathematics, physics take a singular verb

Some nouns appear plural in form but are singular in meaning. Words like “news,” “mathematics,” and “physics” refer to a subject or field of study. Therefore, they take a singular verb. Students often wrongly use plural verbs with such nouns. Understanding their meaning helps avoid mistakes. This rule is important in academic writing. It is frequently tested in grammar exercises. Correct usage improves sentence accuracy.

The news is shocking.

Mathematics is an interesting subject.

Physics requires concentration.

Economics is taught in our school.

Politics is complicated.

Rule 12: “A number of” + plural noun takes a plural verb

The phrase “a number of” means several or many. When followed by a plural noun, it takes a plural verb. The focus is on the quantity of items. Students often confuse this phrase with “the number of.” Understanding the difference between the two is important. This rule is commonly tested in examinations. Correct usage improves sentence clarity. Careful reading helps choose the

correct verb.

A number of students are absent today.

A number of books are missing.

A number of players are injured.

A number of questions are easy.

A number of houses are built here.

Rule 13: “The number of” + plural noun takes a singular verb

The phrase “the number of” refers to the total count of items. When followed by a plural noun, it takes a singular verb. The focus is on the number itself, not the items. Students often confuse this rule with the previous one. Understanding the meaning helps avoid errors. This rule is important in formal writing. Correct usage improves clarity and accuracy.

The number of students is increasing.

The number of books is limited.

The number of cars is rising.

The number of applicants is high.

The number of houses is small.

Rule 14: Titles of books, films, newspapers take a singular verb

Titles of books, films, plays, and newspapers are treated as singular nouns. Even if the title appears plural, it refers to one work. Therefore, a singular verb is used. Students often make mistakes with such titles. Understanding that the title represents one entity helps avoid errors. This rule applies in all tenses. It is important for written English. Correct usage improves grammatical accuracy.

The Times of India is widely read.

Gulliver’s Travels is an interesting book.

The Chronicles of Narnia is popular.



The Avengers is an exciting film.

The Arabian Nights is a famous collection.

Rule 15: Distance, time, money as a unit take a singular verb

When distance, time, or money is considered as a single unit, a singular verb is used. These expressions are treated as one whole. Students often confuse them as plural because they look plural. Understanding the context helps in choosing the correct verb. This rule is common in daily usage. It is often tested in examinations. Correct usage improves sentence accuracy.

Five kilometers is a long distance.

Ten years is a long time.

One hundred rupees is enough.

Two hours is sufficient.

Five days is too short.

Rule 16: Sentences beginning with “there” agree with the real subject

In sentences beginning with “there,” the verb agrees with the real subject that follows it. The word “there” is only an introductory word. Students often mistakenly agree the verb with “there.” Identifying the real subject is very important. This rule applies to both singular and plural subjects. Careful reading helps avoid errors. This rule is common in spoken English. Practice improves understanding.

There is a book on the table.

There are many students in the hall.

There was a loud noise.

There were several mistakes.

There is a problem to solve.

Rule 17: Relative pronouns agree with their antecedent



Relative pronouns agree with the noun that comes before them, called the antecedent. The verb used depends on whether the antecedent is singular or plural. Students often confuse the verb form in such sentences. Understanding the antecedent is necessary to apply this rule. This rule is important in complex sentences. Correct usage improves clarity. It is tested in sentence correction exercises. Regular practice helps master this rule.

She is one of the students who work hard.

He is the only boy who is selected.

This is the book that helps students.

They are the players who practice daily.

She is the girl who sings well.

Rule 18: “One of” + plural noun takes a singular verb

The phrase “one of” refers to a single person or thing chosen from a group. Therefore, it takes a singular verb. Students often mistakenly use plural verbs with this phrase. Understanding the meaning of “one” helps avoid errors. This rule is common in descriptive sentences. It is tested in grammar questions. Correct usage improves sentence structure. Practice helps apply this rule correctly.

She is one of the best students in the class.

He is one of the players who has been selected for the team.

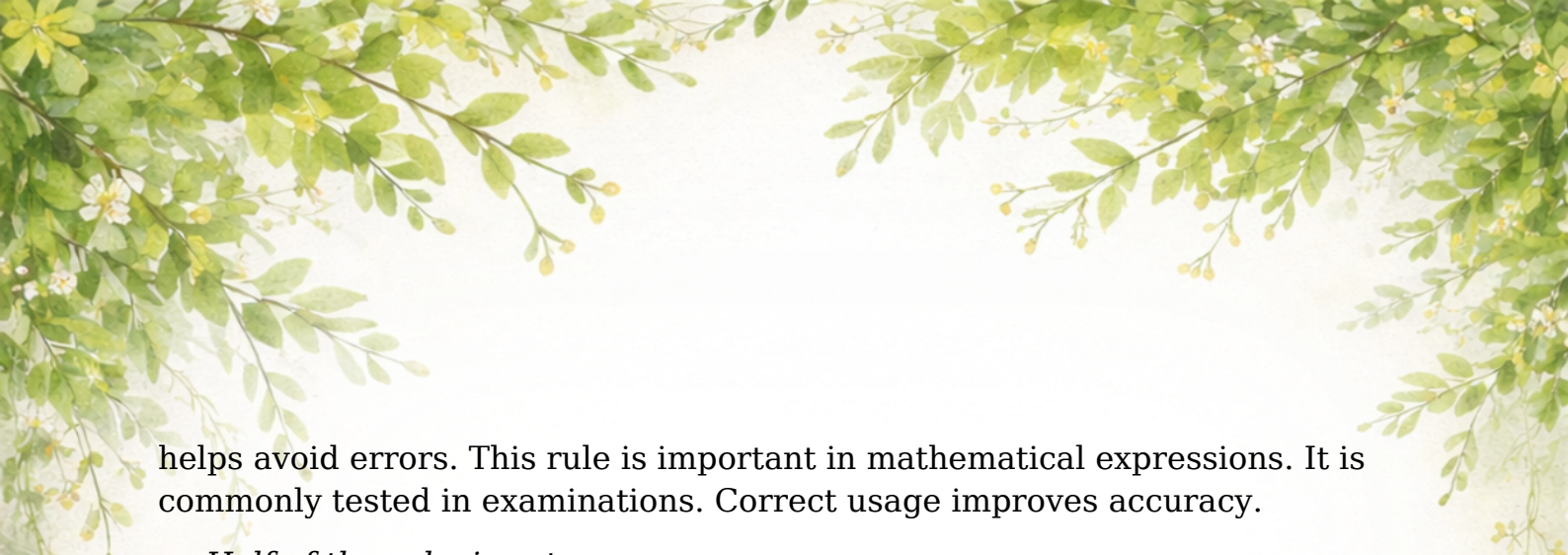
This is one of the houses that was built recently by the government.

She is one of the teachers who teaches mathematics in our school.

That is one of the reasons that was explained by the teacher.

Rule 19: Fractions and percentages depend on the noun after “of”

When fractions or percentages are used, the verb depends on the noun that follows “of.” If the noun is singular, the verb is singular. If the noun is plural, the verb is plural. Students often ignore the noun after “of.” Understanding this rule



helps avoid errors. This rule is important in mathematical expressions. It is commonly tested in examinations. Correct usage improves accuracy.

Half of the cake is eaten.

Half of the students are absent.

Sixty percent of the work is done.

Thirty percent of the players are injured.

One-third of the population lives here.

Rule 20: “Many a” + singular noun takes a singular verb

The phrase “many a” is always followed by a singular noun and a singular verb. Although it refers to more than one person or thing, it is treated as singular in form. Students often make mistakes by using plural verbs. Understanding the structure helps avoid confusion. This rule is mainly used in formal English. It is tested in advanced grammar questions. Correct usage improves sentence quality.

Many a student has failed due to carelessness.

Many a child needs guidance.

Many a time has passed.

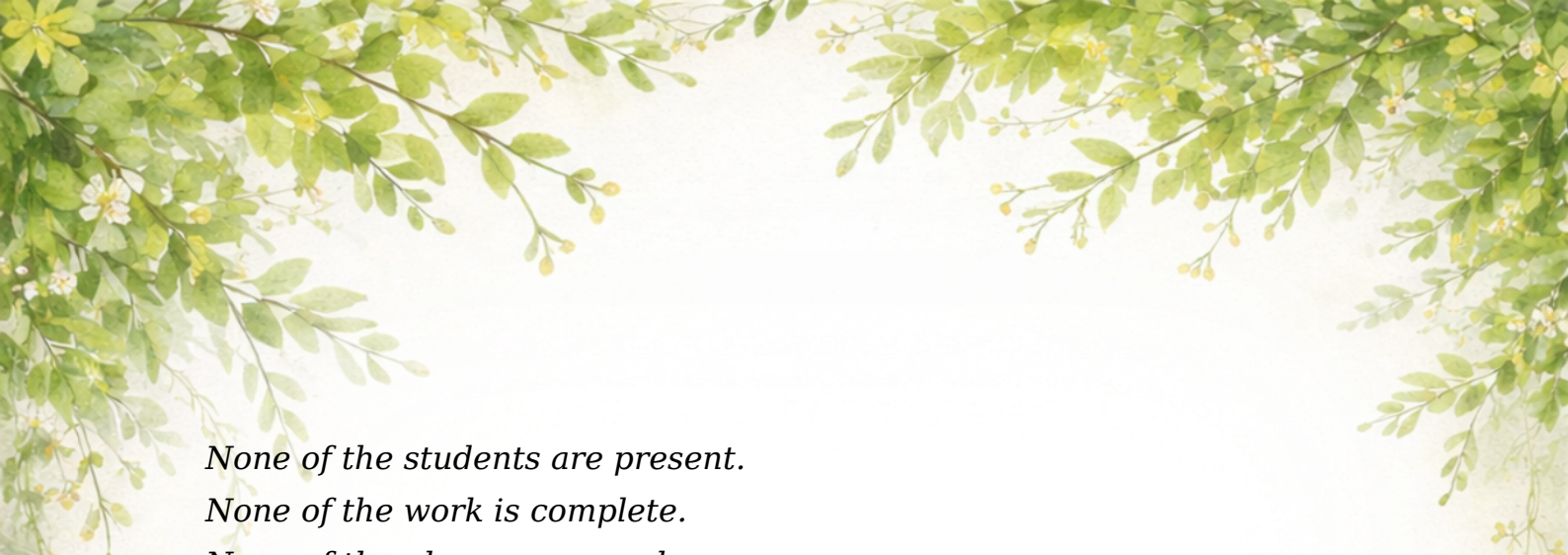
Many a player was injured.

Many a house is damaged.

Rule 21: “None” can be singular or plural depending on meaning

The word “none” can be singular or plural depending on the meaning of the sentence. When it means “not one,” it takes a singular verb. When it means “not any,” it takes a plural verb. Students often use only one form incorrectly. Understanding the context is important. This rule requires careful interpretation. It is tested in higher-level grammar questions. Practice helps master this rule.

None of the money is left.



None of the students are present.
None of the work is complete.
None of the players are ready.
None of the information is correct.

Common Errors to Avoid in Subject-Verb Concord

Many errors in subject-verb concord occur because students fail to identify the correct subject. Long sentences often hide the real subject and confuse learners. Words like “with” and “along with” are wrongly treated as part of the subject. Collective nouns cause confusion when their meaning is not understood clearly. The rule of proximity is often ignored by students. Uncountable nouns are mistakenly treated as plural. Careless reading also leads to incorrect verb choices. Regular practice helps students avoid these common mistakes. Understanding the rules clearly improves grammatical accuracy.

The team wins the match.
Each student has a notebook.
The news is surprising.
Bread and butter is my breakfast.
The number of students is increasing.

Summary

Subject-verb concord is a fundamental rule of English grammar. It ensures agreement between the subject and the verb in number and person. Correct use of this rule makes sentences clear and meaningful. Identifying the subject correctly is the first step in choosing the right verb. Different rules apply in different grammatical situations. Examples help students understand these rules better. This topic is important for school examinations. Regular practice leads to confidence and accuracy. Mastery of subject-verb concord improves overall language skills.

She likes classical music.



*They are ready for the test.
Each boy tries his best.
The class is silent.
Five years is a long time.*

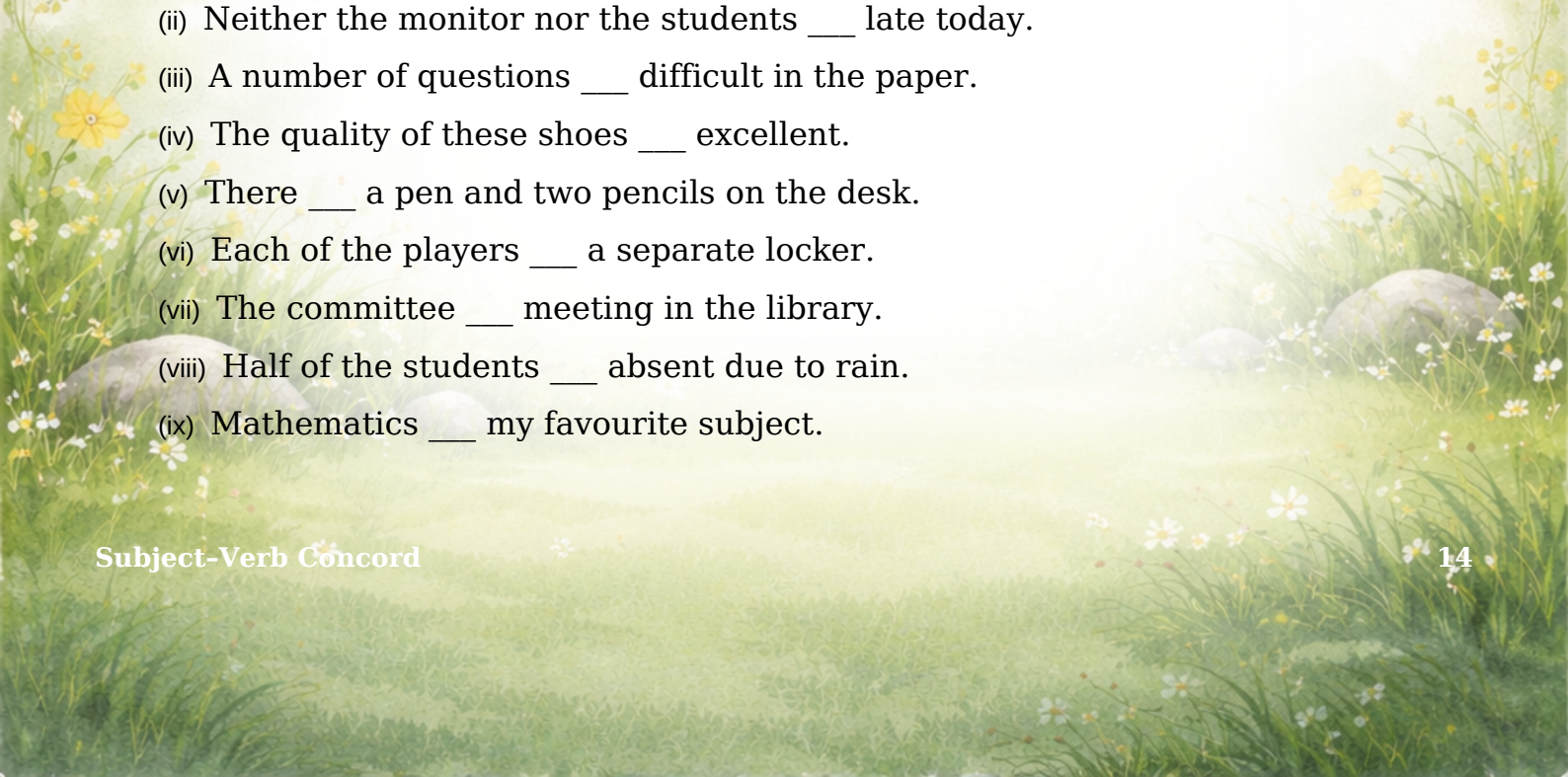


Exercises

1. Identify the Subject-Verb Concord used

- (i) The class is listening quietly.
- (ii) My friends are waiting outside.
- (iii) Each student has submitted the form.
- (iv) The teachers are discussing the timetable.
- (v) The news is spreading fast.
- (vi) There are many chairs in the room.
- (vii) A number of players are practicing early.
- (viii) The number of applicants is rising.
- (ix) My brother and I are preparing for the test.
- (x) None of the water is left in the bottle.

2. Fill in the blanks

- (i) The list of items ___ on the notice board.
 - (ii) Neither the monitor nor the students ___ late today.
 - (iii) A number of questions ___ difficult in the paper.
 - (iv) The quality of these shoes ___ excellent.
 - (v) There ___ a pen and two pencils on the desk.
 - (vi) Each of the players ___ a separate locker.
 - (vii) The committee ___ meeting in the library.
 - (viii) Half of the students ___ absent due to rain.
 - (ix) Mathematics ___ my favourite subject.
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(x) The girl, along with her friends, ___ invited.

3. Choose the correct option

(i) Either the teacher or the students ___ responsible for keeping the room clean.

- (a) is
- (b) are
- (c) was
- (d) were

(ii) The bouquet of roses ___ fresh.

- (a) smell
- (b) smells
- (c) smelling
- (d) smelled

(iii) One of the boys ___ won the prize.

- (a) have
- (b) has
- (c) are
- (d) were

(iv) There ___ many reasons to revise regularly.

- (a) is
- (b) are
- (c) was
- (d) has

(v) The number of pages in this chapter ___ large.

- (a) are
- (b) were
- (c) is
- (d) have

(vi) Everyone in the class ___ the rules.

- (a) follow

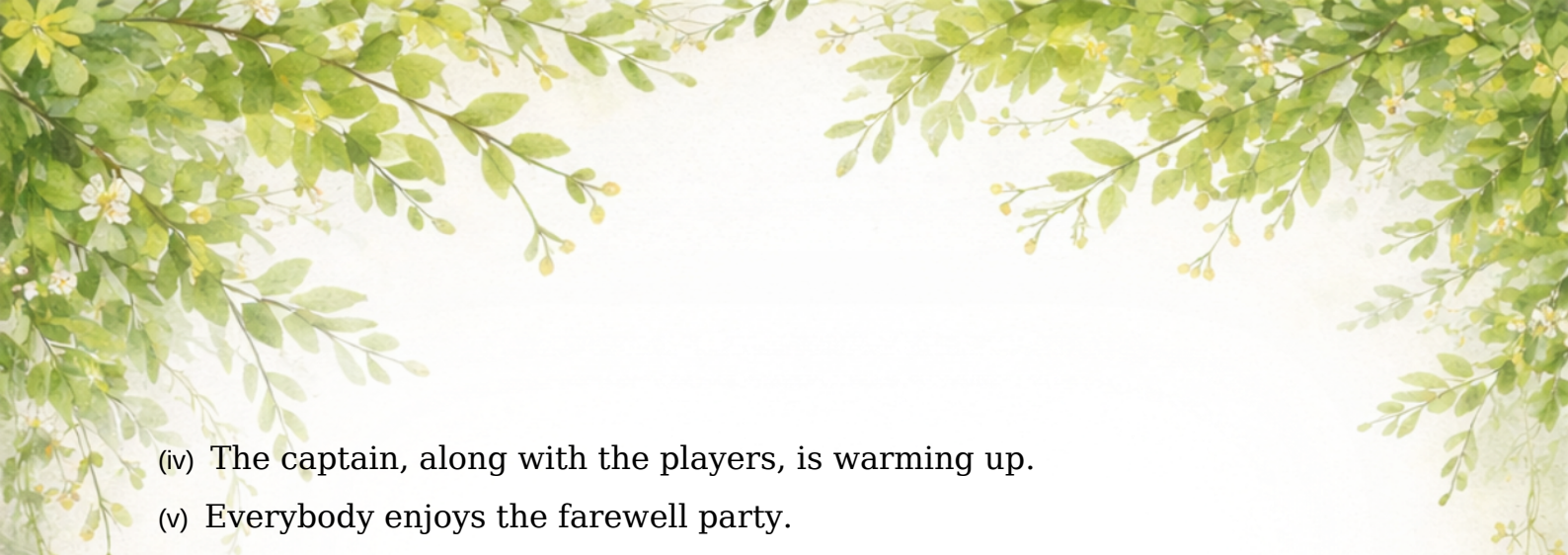
- (b) follows
 (c) following
 (d) followed
- (vii) My parents ___ to the meeting every month.
 (a) comes
 (b) come
 (c) coming
 (d) came
- (viii) Bread and butter ___ my usual breakfast.
 (a) are
 (b) is
 (c) were
 (d) have

4. Match the following

Column A	Column B
(i) Each of the girls	(a) is increasing this year.
(ii) The team	(b) are going to supervise the programme.
(iii) A pair of shoes	(c) has a label on it.
(iv) Either the principal or the teachers	(d) wins the match with practice.
(v) The number of students	(e) needs a separate timetable.

5. Identify the rule used

- (i) Riya and her sister are preparing for the annual function.
 (ii) The poet and teacher is speaking on stage.
 (iii) Neither the books nor the bag is missing.

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- (iv) The captain, along with the players, is warming up.
(v) Everybody enjoys the farewell party.
(vi) The committee meets on Monday.
(vii) The family are planning different trips.
(viii) Information is stored safely on the computer.
(ix) Physics is taught by a new teacher.
(x) A number of students are volunteering for the drive.

6. Multiple choice questions

- (i) Many a student ___ nervous before the viva.
(a) feel
(b) feels
(c) are
(d) were
- (ii) Half of the milk ___ spilled.
(a) are
(b) is
(c) were
(d) have
- (iii) None of the players ___ ready yet.
(a) is
(b) are
(c) was
(d) has
- (iv) The Times of India ___ delivered early.
(a) are
(b) is
(c) were
(d) have
- 

(v) Ten minutes ___ enough to revise this poem.

- (a) are
- (b) is
- (c) were
- (d) have

(vi) There ___ two notebooks on my desk.

- (a) is
- (b) are
- (c) was
- (d) has

(vii) One of my friends ___ in the school band.

- (a) play
- (b) plays
- (c) playing
- (d) played

(viii) The class ___ writing the test now.

- (a) is
- (b) are
- (c) were
- (d) have

(ix) A number of houses ___ painted recently.

- (a) is
- (b) are
- (c) was
- (d) has

(x) The number of applicants ___ very high.

- (a) are
- (b) is
- (c) were
- (d) have

7. Spot the error and correct it

- (i) The list of names are on the table.
- (ii) Each of the students have a notebook.
- (iii) The team are winning every match this season.
- (iv) Neither the teacher nor the students is late.
- (v) A number of books is missing from the shelf.
- (vi) The number of seats are limited.
- (vii) Mathematics are difficult for me.
- (viii) There is many reasons to study daily.
- (ix) Many a player were injured in the match.
- (x) None of the answers are correct.

8. Correct the paragraph

The students of our class is preparing for the annual exam.
Each boy and each girl have a separate timetable.
Riya as well as her friends are studying in the library.
A number of chapters is very important for grammar practice.
The number of mistakes in my answers are reducing slowly.
Neither the teacher nor the monitor know the correct schedule.
There was many questions on subject verb agreement in the test.
The news about the result are spreading quickly in the school.
My brother and my cousin is going to attend the extra class.
Bread and butter are my favourite breakfast before exams.
Every student in the room know the rule of proximity.
Half of the pages is missing from my notebook.
Many a student have forgotten to revise the rules.
One of the players are absent today due to fever.
The team are playing well as a single unit.
The family is arguing among themselves after the meeting.
None of the books is kept in the correct shelf.
Two hours are enough to finish the entire workbook.



The teacher with the students are waiting for the bell.
The committee are meeting today to plan the farewell.



Answer Sheet

1. Identify the Subject-Verb Concord used

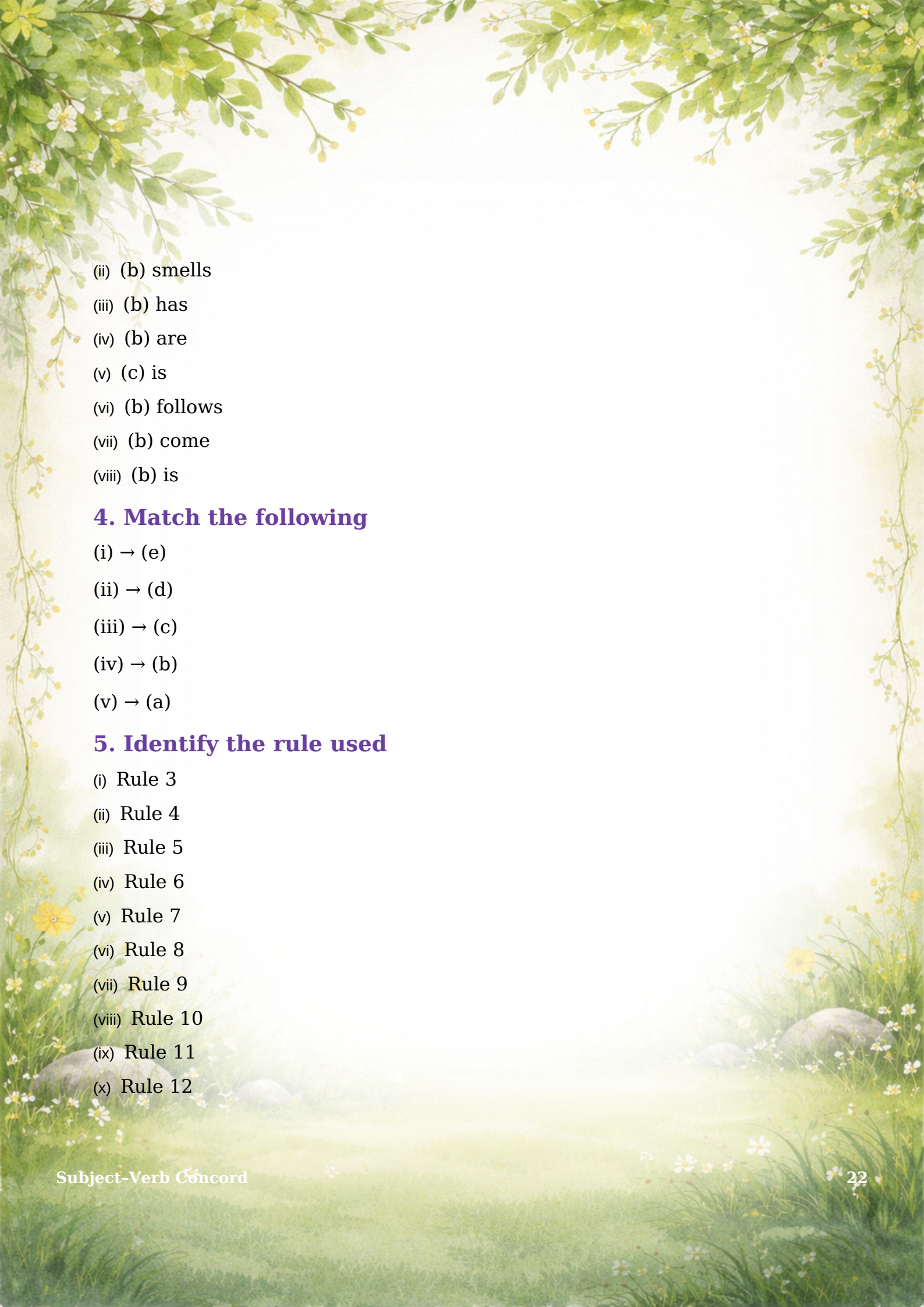
- (i) Singular subject – singular verb
- (ii) Plural subject – plural verb
- (iii) Singular subject – singular verb
- (iv) Plural subject – plural verb
- (v) Singular subject – singular verb
- (vi) Plural subject – plural verb
- (vii) Plural subject – plural verb
- (viii) Singular subject – singular verb
- (ix) Plural subject – plural verb
- (x) Singular subject – singular verb

2. Fill in the blanks

- (i) is
- (ii) are
- (iii) are
- (iv) is
- (v) is
- (vi) has
- (vii) is
- (viii) are
- (ix) is
- (x) is

3. Choose the correct option

- (i) (b) are

- 
- (ii) (b) smells
 - (iii) (b) has
 - (iv) (b) are
 - (v) (c) is
 - (vi) (b) follows
 - (vii) (b) come
 - (viii) (b) is

4. Match the following

- (i) → (e)
- (ii) → (d)
- (iii) → (c)
- (iv) → (b)
- (v) → (a)

5. Identify the rule used

- (i) Rule 3
- (ii) Rule 4
- (iii) Rule 5
- (iv) Rule 6
- (v) Rule 7
- (vi) Rule 8
- (vii) Rule 9
- (viii) Rule 10
- (ix) Rule 11
- (x) Rule 12



6. Multiple choice questions

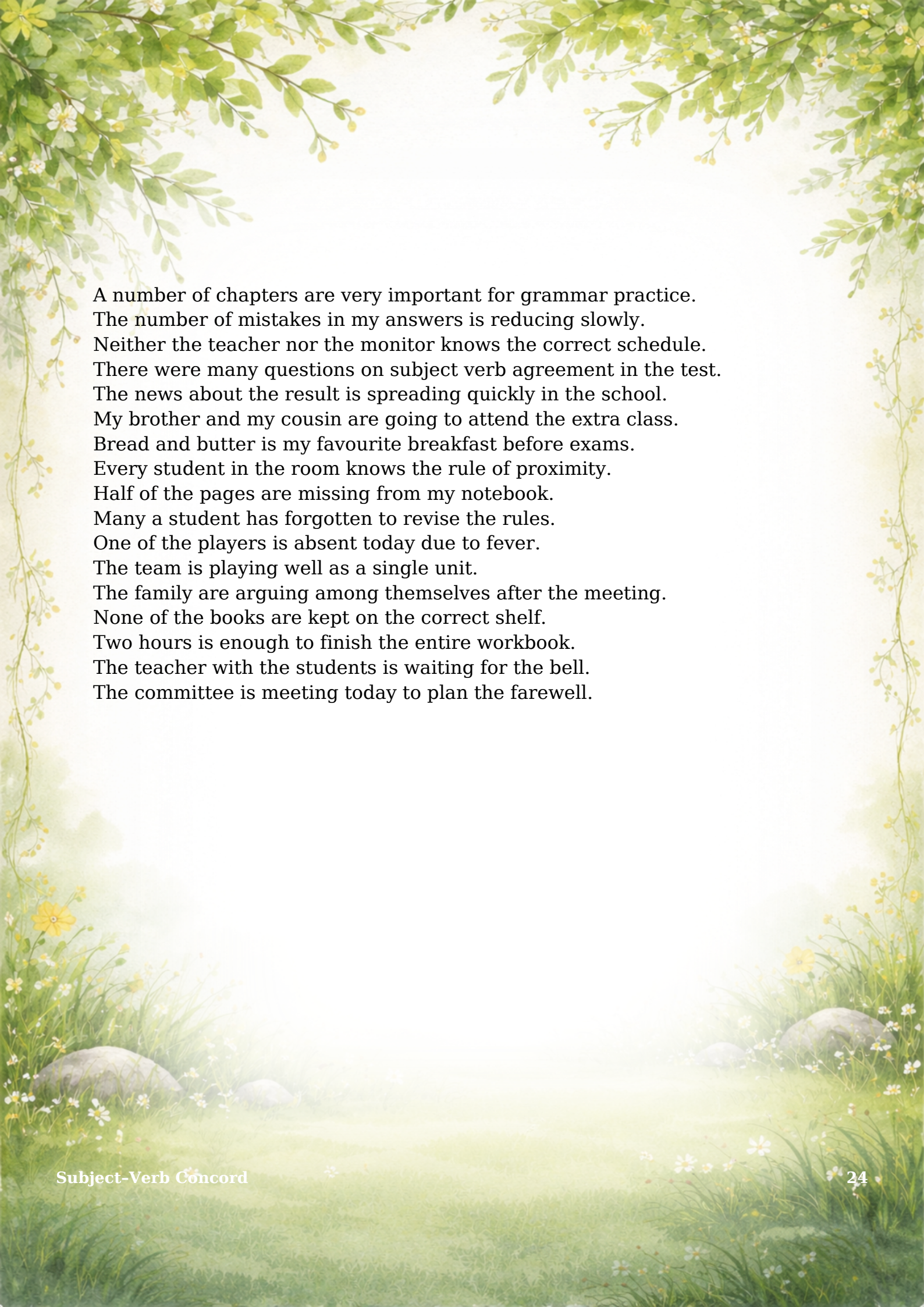
- (i) (b) feels
- (ii) (b) is
- (iii) (b) are
- (iv) (b) is
- (v) (b) is
- (vi) (b) are
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- (ix) (b) are
- (x) (b) is

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The team is playing well as a single unit.
The family are arguing among themselves after the meeting.
None of the books are kept on the correct shelf.
Two hours is enough to finish the entire workbook.
The teacher with the students is waiting for the bell.
The committee is meeting today to plan the farewell.